Portugal: energy security, economic opportunity and partnership priorities

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AI-generated from the data and checked against it; paper baseline as of 12 October 2026.

Summary

- Portugal's lowest Energy Security percentiles are in downstream coal and downstream gas, where it scores higher than only 1% and 3% of the other economies scored. Low and falling use per person pulls both scores down.[1]
- Its highest Economic Opportunity percentiles are in downstream geothermal, midstream oil and midstream coal, higher than 98%, 97% and 97% of the other economies scored, mainly because of its cost competitiveness.[1]
- On the paper's weighting, the Strategic Index ranks downstream batteries 1st and upstream wind 2nd among Portugal's own sectors. Policy activity ranks the former 1st but the latter only 11th.[1,2]
- The Partnership Strength Index rates Spain highest for Portugal, as a reliable supplier; it is also its 1st trade partner. China, its 2nd trade partner, ranks only 65th on Partnership Strength.[1,3]

1. Energy security risks and why

11 of Portugal's 30 placed sectors sit in the two low-energy-security corners, below the middle economy of their sector on Energy Security, which measures how well a country can rely on what it needs. Its lowest Energy Security percentiles are in downstream coal (score 0.29, Secure corner) and downstream gas (0.35, Secure corner), higher than only 1% and 3% of the other economies scored. Both are pulled down mainly by the energy access category, which measures use per person and its change. Over the years to 2025, coal use per person changed by -99.1%, to 0.0201 GJ per person; gas use changed by -32.5%, to 14.1 GJ per person.[1,4]

Next come upstream oil (0.36, Upgrade corner) and upstream gas (0.26, Upgrade corner), higher than 11% and 12% of the other economies scored. Both are low mainly because of energy imports and reserves. Production minus consumption was -0.445 EJ for oil and -0.147 EJ for gas in 2025. Both figures take production from the U.S. Energy Information Administration's international statistics, as the Energy Institute does not report it separately. No oil or gas reserves are recorded, which the index counts as zero. For context, its largest suppliers of upstream oil in 2024 were Brazil (29.9% of imports) and Algeria (13.1%).[1,3,4,5]

Its high-priority sectors, upstream wind, upstream electric grid and upstream green hydrogen, sit in the Upgrade corner, which pairs high opportunity with low energy security. In upstream wind, its Energy Security of 0.25 sits just under the sector median of 0.26, mainly because of the trade category. Its trade deficit in these goods was <0.1% of GDP in 2023, a measure on which it scores higher than 23% of the other economies. For context, its upstream wind imports totalled USD 264 k in 2024; China supplied 48.5% and Austria 39.3%.[1,3,6]

2. Economic opportunities and why

28 of its 30 placed sectors sit in the two high-opportunity corners, above the middle economy of their sector on Economic Opportunity, which measures how well placed a country is to create value. Its highest Economic Opportunity percentiles are in downstream geothermal (0.42), midstream oil (0.66) and midstream coal (0.54). There it scores higher than 98%, 97% and 97% of the other economies scored. Each sits in the Grow corner, which the framework associates with building on strength through export promotion.[1]

Cost competitiveness pushes each of them up: on input costs for labour and capital, Portugal scores higher than 98% of the other economies in midstream oil. In the midstream sectors the trade category adds to the score. Export feasibility, how close these goods are to what it already exports well, was 0.36 in midstream oil and 0.36 in midstream coal in 2023. For context, its largest markets for midstream oil in 2024 were Spain (21.1%) and the United Kingdom (11.4%).[1,3,6]

The same cost competitiveness and trade categories push up its opportunity in upstream wind and upstream electric grid, which are high-priority sectors. In upstream wind, where its Economic Opportunity is higher than 92% of the other economies scored, it scores higher than 94% of them on input costs.[1]

3. Sectoral priorities and the existing policy posture

The Strategic Index ranks a country's own sectors by opportunity, security need, policy activity, stage and low-emission value. On the paper's weighting, it ranks downstream batteries 1st among Portugal's own sectors, at 0.67, 0.013 ahead of the next. Its lead rests on policy activity, where it ranks 1st; on priority, the Strategic Index without its policy term, it ranks 13th. Next come upstream wind (2nd), midstream batteries (3rd), upstream nuclear (4th) and upstream electric grid (5th). Each is almost tied with the sector below it, by 0.008, 0.001, 0.004 and 0.003.[1,2]

Portugal's allied pick, its top upstream or midstream sector after a resource screen, is midstream batteries, almost tied with upstream nuclear (0.001 apart). The higher-ranked upstream wind is screened out, as the data record no resource base for it.[7]

Policy activity counts International Energy Agency policy records and the Climate Action Tracker rating, which favours low-emission technologies over coal, oil and gas. Portugal has 261 such records, 144 of which name a technology, and carries the European Union's Climate Action Tracker rating, Insufficient. Policy activity and priority partly agree: no top priority has the least policy. Among the top priorities, policy activity is weakest in upstream green hydrogen and midstream green hydrogen, both in the top third on priority but only 20th and 19th on policy. Among the bottom priorities, the most policy goes to downstream green hydrogen and the least to 7 coal, oil and gas sectors. For context, the Country Insights page lists, by sector, the strongest active industrial-policy measures that Global Trade Alert records under Portugal, including EU-wide ones; they do not count towards policy activity.[1,2,8]

4. Partnership priorities and why

From Portugal's viewpoint, the Partnership Strength Index rates Spain highest, as a reliable supplier strongest in midstream wind, upstream solar, midstream solar, midstream electric vehicles and upstream electric grid. The index combines how reliable a supplier a partner is (Friendshore), how good a market it is (Partnership Opportunity) and, for lower-income partners, Development Potential. The Netherlands ranks 2nd, also as a reliable supplier, followed by France (3rd, export market) and Germany (4th, export market).[1]

Today's ties match these ranks in part. Spain, France and Germany are its 1st, 3rd and 4th trade partners on average across its energy-goods baskets. The Netherlands, by contrast, is only its 12th. Conversely, China is its 2nd trade partner, yet ranks 65th on Partnership Strength and rates best as a development partner. Spain, the Netherlands, France and Germany each share NATO membership with Portugal and vote in the same bloc at the United Nations. China shares none of its economic-security agreements, and their votes put them in opposite blocs.[1,3,9,10]

As a partner to the coalition, Portugal ranks 16th of 192 economies on Partnership Strength averaged over the core members' viewpoints. In the allied network design its shares are derived from the European Union's: they are largest in midstream green hydrogen (0.4% of designed coalition production) and midstream wind (0.3%).[1,7]

5. Data notes and caveats

Figures are as of 12 October 2026. Scores compare Portugal with other economies in the same sector; they are not measures of risk or profit in absolute terms. All index values are the paper's baseline as of 12 October 2026; Strategic Insights recomputes them under other weightings. Some figures behind these scores are filled in where the source has no value: with zero where a source lists every holder, otherwise with the world average. Strategic Index scores within 0.01 of each other are almost tied: small changes in the data or the weights can swap their order. Many allied picks are close calls: in the paper, 37% of them are within 0.01 of the runner-up. In the allied network design the European Union is one producer; Portugal's shares are derived from its weight within the EU. The Climate Action Tracker rates the EU as a whole; Portugal carries the EU's rating. Portugal's counts leave out the EU's own 438 International Energy Agency policy records. Trade figures count trade with other EU members.

Sources

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